l 7

On July 23, 1952, we read in the paper that Laurence Oncley had died. He was a biochemist at Harvard whom we had met through Bill Boyd. Oncley was a tall and large man, soft-voiced and pleasant, and Gertrude and I liked him. The news was shocking. He had had leukemia for fourteen months, the news report said, and we marveled at how he had managed to hold up, remain cheerful, never let on. It was absolutely inspirational and we mourned his passing.

Then when we visited the Boyds sometime later, Larry Oncley walked in. Gertrude and I went to pieces. You don't come across three-dimensional ghosts often. What happened was, of course, that Larry was Laurence Oncley, Jr., and the obituary had referred to Laurence Oncley, Sr.

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At about this time I was making out a will for the first time. Until now it was just a matter of leaving everything to Gertrude. With a child, I would also have to provide for him in case Gertrude and I died in a common disaster, so I felt I could put it off no more. For the same reason, I took out my first batch of life insurance.

That made me aware of my steadily increasing weight. On June 30, 1952, I weighed just 200 pounds stripped—some 55 pounds more than I weighed when I was married, and 30 pounds more than when I entered the Army.

I decided to go on a diet and even consulted a doctor about it. The doctor was Robert Cataldo (we had, after all, moved away from Dr. Adler), a small man, with a head shaved to mere stubble, and who spoke in an ingratiating whisper. Dr. Cataldo drove me slowly crazy by going through his usual routine of informing his patient on the facts concerning diet. Considering that I had written the "Lipids and Obesity" chapter in the textbook, there was nothing he could possibly tell me that I didn't know.

I did lose a few pounds as a result, but as is common in such cases, it didn't stay off.

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On August 4, Fred wrote to tell me that Tony Boucher had rejected a story of mine called "The Deep/' which I had written as a deliberate test as to whether you could do anything in science fiction. In this story, I invented a society in